

Asian Englishes World Englishes

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What Are World Englishes?

Definition:

- The global varieties of English spoken in diverse cultural, social, and linguistic contexts.
- Includes **Inner Circle**, **Outer Circle**, and **Expanding Circle** Englishes (Kachru, 1985).

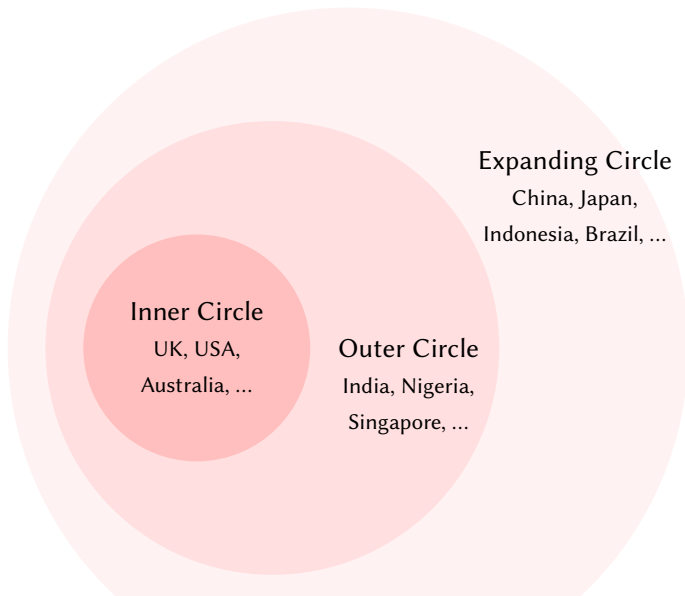
Importance:

- Reflects the spread of English as a global lingua franca.
- Highlights the adaptability and localization of English in different regions, especially in Asia.

Examples:

- British English, Indian English, Chinese English, Nigerian English.

Kachru's Three Circles of English



The Inner Circle

Definition:

- Represents countries where English is the native language and primary means of communication.

Examples:

- United Kingdom, United States, Australia, Canada, New Zealand.

Key Features:

- England and former settler colonies where English became dominant (USA, Canada, Australia, New Zealand).
- Sets linguistic norms often viewed as “standard” English.
- Used as a cultural identifier.

The Outer Circle

Definition:

- Countries where English serves as a second language, often used in government, education, and business.
- Reflects historical colonial influence.

Examples:

- India, Nigeria, Singapore, Philippines.
- Singapore fits almost all characteristics of inner circle except origin, ...

Key Features:

- Nativized varieties of English.
- High degree of multilingualism among speakers.
- Functional roles in administration and education.
- More speakers than the inner circle

The Expanding Circle

Definition:

- Countries where English is used as a foreign language.
- Primarily for international communication and business.

Examples:

- China, Japan, Brazil, Russia.

Key Features:

- Does not have a colonial legacy of English.
- Lacks institutionalized functions in government or education.
- Growing role in globalization and digital communication.
- Has the most speakers!

English-speaking populations across various countries.

Country	Population	Speakers	First L	Other L
United States	312,092,668	297,400,000	244,232,103	42,155,719
India	1,450,000,000	228,539,090	259,678	228,279,412
Nigeria	206,200,000	125,039,680	20,000,000	103,198,040
Pakistan	220,892,331	108,044,691	8,642	108,036,049
United Kingdom	64,000,000	62,912,000	59,072,000	3,840,000
Philippines	110,000,000	70,117,935	36,935	70,081,000
Germany	80,600,000	45,400,000	392,000	45,100,000
Uganda	44,270,000	19,800,000	0	19,800,000
France	67,500,000	38,643,750	0	38,643,750
Canada	37,138,500	30,480,750	20,193,335	10,287,415
Egypt	110,990,000	44,373,802	5,527,302	38,846,500
Australia	23,401,892	21,715,910	17,020,421	4,695,489
Bangladesh	165,323,100	19,838,772	709,873	16,398,158
Poland	38,501,000	18,890,000	103,541	18,786,459
Ghana	27,000,000	18,000,000	0	18,000,000
Singapore	4,044,200	3,900,000	1,953,348	1,946,652

Data from Wikipedia: List of countries by English-speaking population

World Englishes: Quirk vs. Kachru

Quirk's Perspective (Uniformity View, 1985):

- Emphasizes a single, standardized form of English based on Inner Circle norms (e.g., UK, US).
- Concerns about intelligibility and global communication.
- Argues that legitimizing non-standard varieties risks misunderstanding.
We need one standard English for effective international communication

Kachru's Perspective (Pluralist View, 1985):

- Advocates for the legitimacy of Outer Circle varieties (e.g., Indian, Nigerian English).
- Emphasizes linguistic and cultural adaptation (nativization).
- Critiques the deficit model of “errors” and promotes ownership of English by all its users. *English belongs to all its users, not just its historical 'native' speakers.*

Key Themes of the Debate

- **Standardization vs. Diversity:**

- Quirk: Standardization is essential for global intelligibility.
- Kachru: Diversity reflects the realities of English use worldwide.

- **Pedagogical Implications:**

- Quirk: Teaching should adhere to Inner Circle norms.
- Kachru: Teaching should validate localized varieties.

- **Ownership of English:**

- Quirk: English belongs to the Inner Circle.
- Kachru: English is the global property of all its users.

Four “False Assumptions” about English (Kachru, 1992)

1. The Homogeneity Assumption:

- **Assumption:** There is a single, homogeneous standard English.
- **Counterpoint:** Inner Circle varieties themselves exhibit variation.

2. The Deficit Model of Non-Native Varieties:

- **Assumption:** Outer Circle Englishes are “deviant” or deficient.
- **Counterpoint:** Outer Circle varieties are contextually legitimate adaptations.

3. The Pedagogical Purity Assumption:

- **Assumption:** Teaching should focus on Inner Circle norms exclusively.
- **Counterpoint:** Teaching should reflect local linguistic realities.

4. The Intelligibility Assumption:

- **Assumption:** Inner Circle norms guarantee mutual intelligibility.
- **Counterpoint:** Intelligibility is context-dependent and mutual.

Innovation – Deviation – Mistake (Kachru, 1992)

Key Distinctions:

- **Innovation:** Creativity in language use; often denied to Outer and Expanding Circle speakers.
Examples: timepass, skinship, add oil.
- **Deviation:** Comparison with another variety; implies departure from a norm.
Example (vs. Inner Circle norm): He is knowing the answer.
- **Mistake (or error):** Related to acquisitional deficiency; not accepted in any stable speech community.
Example: He knowed the answer.

Different varieties are held to different standards!

Standards Across Space

Three often-cited “standard” varieties:

- British English (BrE), North American English (especially AmE), and Australian English (AusE).
- Similarities and differences:
 - Across the three standards.
 - Across varieties within each region (e.g., different UK or US dialects).
- Pronunciation
- Vocabulary: The Most Noticeable Divergence (NAmE vs. BrE)
 - **Extended meanings:** e.g., *corn*, *robin*.
 - **New words:** e.g., *bottle* “to act as a butler”.
 - **Borrowings:** e.g., *moccasin*, *squash*, *toboggan*.
- Since US independence:
 - Technological terms: e.g., *windshield* vs. *windscreen*.

Australian English

Key Features:

- Borrowings from Aboriginal languages: e.g., *kangaroo*, *boomerang*.
- Unique slang words and phrases.
- Common use of abbreviations and clippings.
barbie “bbq”, *uni* “university”, *sanger* “sandwich”, *relly* “relative”, *chuck a U-ey* “make a U-turn”
Snowy “person with white hair”, *Bluey* “red-head”, *Bondie* “Bond (me)”

Quite a lot of Grammar Differences

AmE vs. BrE (Trudgill and Hannah, 2002):

- **Verbs:** Morphology, auxiliaries.
 - US: *He did already eat.* vs. UK: *He has already eaten.*
- **Nouns:** Endings, use of verbs as nouns.
 - US: *Please action this.* vs. UK: *Please do this/act on this.*
- **Adjectives and Adverbs:**
 - US: *He runs real fast.* vs. UK: *He runs really fast.*
 - US: *How big of a room is it?* vs. UK: *How big a room is it?*
- **Prepositions:**
 - US: *I went on the weekend.* vs. UK: *I went at the weekend.*

Native and Non-Native Speakers of English

Criticisms of NS/NNS Terms:

- NS = *native speaker*, NNS = *non-native speaker* (apparently simple labels, but problematic).
- Assumes monolingualism is the norm.
- Overemphasizes order of acquisition.
- Reinforces Anglo speakers as reference points.
- Implies unidirectional power relationships.
- Encourages simplistic views of “errors.”
- What do these labels suggest about *you* as speakers of English?

Alternatives to NS/NNS Distinction

Rampton (1990): “Experts” → Expertise

- Advantages:
 - Learned, not innate.
 - Relative, partial, and contestable.
- Disadvantages:
 - “Non-expert” implies value judgment.

Jenkins (2000): MES, BES, NBES

- MES: Monolingual English Speaker.
- BES: Bilingual English Speaker.
- NBES: Non-Bilingual English Speaker.
- Emphasizes speakers’ bilingual repertoires rather than a simple native vs. non-native divide.

Naming the Varieties: Labels and Ideology

Names are not neutral: they index attitudes, power, and ownership.

- **Indian English:** *Hinglish*

Hinglish highlights code-mixing and youth / pop-culture identities, but can also stereotype.

- **Singapore & Malaysian English:** *Singlish* / *Manglish*

In official discourse we often find *Colloquial Singapore English* (CSE).

Government campaigns (*Speak Good English*) frame *Singlish* as a problem, while speakers use the name to index solidarity and local identity.

- **Hong Kong English:** *Chinglish*

Labels like *Chinglish* are common in media but are usually mocking or deficit-oriented, focusing on “errors” in signs or speech.

- **Japanese English, wasei-eigo:** *Japlish*, *Engrish*

Japanese English and *wasei-eigo* are descriptive terms used in linguistics.

Informal labels like *Engrish* or *Japlish* are often used from outside Japan and carry racist / mocking connotations.

Activity: How Would You Label Yourself?

- In small groups, discuss which labels you prefer:
 - NS / NNS
 - MES / BES / NBES
 - Something else entirely?
- How do these labels affect:
 - how confident you feel when speaking English?
 - how you evaluate other people's English?
- Who gets to name a variety (state, teachers, speakers, outsiders)?
How do different labels affect the *prestige* and *legitimacy* of these Englishes?

En Route to New Standard Englishes

Codification of Asian Englishes:

- Importance:
 - Acceptance, prestige, classroom model.
- Obstacles:
 - Indigenized varieties seen as “interlanguages.”
 - SLA perspective emphasizes NS-like competence.
 - Motivation for acquisition is integrative (admiration for NS culture).

Characteristics of Asian Englishes

Distinct Features:

- **Phonology:** Unique accents and stress patterns (e.g., Indian English retroflex sounds).
- **Syntax:** Influence of local languages (e.g., omission of articles in Singapore English).
- **Lexicon:** Borrowings and cultural terms (e.g., *chop* “seal/stamp” in Malaysian English).
- Extensive code-switching

What is Indian English?

- Indian English refers to the variety of English spoken in India.
- It is influenced by India's multilingual environment and local languages.
- Features unique vocabulary, pronunciation, grammar, and idiomatic expressions.
- Recognized as one of the most widespread second languages in India.

Key Features of Indian English

- **Pronunciation:**

- Often rhotic: Pronouncing /r/ in words like *car* and *farm*.
- Vowel quality may differ from US/UK norms (e.g., *bat*, *bad*, *bed*).

- **Vocabulary:**

- Unique words like *prepone* “to reschedule earlier” and *godown* “warehouse”.

- **Grammar:**

- Use of the progressive tense: *He is knowing the answer*.
- Use of *doubt* in the sense of “question”: *He is having a doubt in mathematics*.

Unique Vocabulary in Indian English

- **Borrowed words:**

- *bungalow* (from Hindi: “bangla”)
- *jungle* (from Hindi: “jangal”)

- **Hybrid expressions:**

- *pass out* “to graduate”
- *out of station* “not in town”

- **Local adaptations:**

- *hill station* “mountain resort”
- *timepass* “leisure activity”
- *revert* “reply” (also used in Manglish/Singlish)

Examples of Indian English Sentences

- *Can you prepone the meeting to tomorrow?*
- *I passed out of college in 2020.*
- *He is having a doubt in mathematics.*
- *She went to the market to buy vegetables only.*
- *Let us go for a walk in the evening, no?*

Cultural and Linguistic Significance

- Indian English reflects the diversity of India's languages and cultures.
- It bridges communication gaps in a multilingual society.
- Used in government, education, business, and media.
- Contributes to the global spread of English with a distinct identity.

What is Singlish?

- Singlish is the colloquial form of English spoken in Singapore.
- It combines English with elements from Malay, Tamil, Hokkien, Cantonese, and other languages.
- Singlish is informal and often spoken in casual settings.
- Although not officially endorsed, it is a key part of Singaporean identity.

Examples of Singlish Vocabulary

- **Lah:** *Don't worry lah!* (adds emphasis or assurance)
- **Kiasu:** *He is so kiasu.* “fear of missing out”
- **Shiok:** *This food is so shiok!* “delicious or enjoyable”
- **Blur:** *Why are you so blur?* “confused or clueless”
- **Paiseh:** *So paiseh to ask!* “embarrassed”
- **Ang moh:** *The ang moh loves laksa.* (Caucasian - lit: red head)

Try our Singlish Dictionary!

Singlish Grammar and Syntax

- **Aspect through adverbs, not tense:**
 - *He go already.* “He has already gone.”
- **Tag particles:**
 - *You want coffee, ah?* (adds a questioning tone)
 - *Very expensive, leh.* (adds emphasis)
- **Omission of articles/plurality:**
 - *I go market.* “I am going to the market.”
 - *I buy 3 book.* “I will buy three books.”

Cultural and Linguistic Significance

- Singlish reflects Singapore's multicultural heritage.
- It fosters a sense of local identity and camaraderie.
- Often used in media, humor, and casual conversations.
- Despite government efforts to promote Standard English, Singlish remains a vibrant and unique aspect of Singaporean culture.

What is Hong Kong English?

- Hong Kong English is the variety of English influenced by Cantonese, the primary language spoken in Hong Kong.
- Developed due to British colonial rule (1842–1997) and remains significant in education, business, and law.
- Reflects a blend of British English, local linguistic features, and Cantonese cultural influence.

Key Features of Hong Kong English

- **Pronunciation:**

- Influence of Cantonese tones on stress patterns.
- Some speakers may neutralize /r/ and /l/, producing similar sounds in words like *rice* and *lice*.

- **Grammar:**

- Omission of articles and prepositions: *I go market* “I am going to the market”.

- **Vocabulary:**

- Loanwords from Cantonese: *yum cha* “drink tea” and *char siu* “roast pork”.

Examples of Hong Kong English Vocabulary

- **Loanwords from Cantonese:**

- ***Dai pai dong:*** Open-air food stalls.
- ***Si fu:*** Master or skilled worker.
- ***Cha chaan teng:*** Hong Kong-style cafes.

- **Hybrid expressions:**

- ***Add oil:*** An encouragement or cheer, meaning *keep going* or “good luck.”
- ***Long time no see:*** Often described as a calque from the Cantonese phrase “好耐冇見” (hou noi mou gin), though the exact origin is debated.

Common Features of Sentences in Hong Kong English

- **Direct translations from Cantonese:**

- *He very smart, la.* “He is very smart, you know.”

- **Different grammatical elements:**

- *I no understand.* “I do not understand.”

- **Unique phrases:**

- *I go yum cha with family tomorrow.* “I am going to have dim sum with my family tomorrow.”

Cultural and Linguistic Significance

- Hong Kong English reflects the region's colonial past and its Cantonese-speaking majority.
- It plays a key role in education, government, and international business.
- Highlights the blending of British and Chinese cultures in Hong Kong.
- Despite its informal and localized nature, it remains an essential aspect of Hong Kong's identity and communication in multilingual settings.

What is Japanese English?

- Japanese English refers to the variety of English influenced by the Japanese language.
 - Informal labels like *Japlish* or *Engrish* are sometimes used for English produced by Japanese speakers, often in a mocking or racist way.
 - 和製英語 *wasei eigo* “Japanese-made English” are English-like words used in Japanese.
- It often features adaptations of English words and phrases to fit Japanese phonetics and culture.
 - Inserting vowels: *table* becomes *te-buru*.
 - No distinction between /l/ and /r/: *light* and *right* sound similar.
 - Fewer consonant clusters
 - A tendency to shorten things
- Developed due to English education, international business, and cultural exchange.
- Known for unique loanwords, katakana usage, and creative expressions.

Examples of Wasei Eigo

● Adapted loanwords:

- *sarariman* (salaryman) “male office worker”
- *o-eru* (OL: office lady) “female office worker”
- *hando phon* (hand phone) “Mobile phone (from *handy phone*)”
- *baikingu* (viking) “buffet” (because Scandinavians like *smorgasbord*)

● Creative coinages:

- *mai pe-su* (my pace) “going at one’s own speed”
- *seku-hara* “sexual harassment”
- *pawa-hara* (power harassment) “workplace bullying”
- *konbini* “convenience store”
- *sukinshippu* (skinship) “physical closeness or bonding”
- *ha-to furu* (heartful) “warm-hearted, caring”

Cultural and Linguistic Significance

- Japanese English showcases the cultural blending of Japan and the English-speaking world.
- Reflects creative adaptations to fit Japanese language structure and social norms.
- Plays an important role in education, tourism, and advertising in Japan.
- Despite challenges with pronunciation and syntax, it has become a unique and recognizable form of English globally.

The Future of Asian Englishes

Trends:

- Increasing prestige and global recognition.
- Growth of English as a second language in Asia.
- Integration into educational systems and digital platforms.

Key Questions:

- How will globalization shape Asian Englishes?
- Will codification lead to the emergence of new standards?
- How can we balance intelligibility and diversity?

Prestige and “Non-Standard” Varieties in the Inner Circle

- **Australian English** (*Strine*) Historically stigmatized as “broad” or “lazy” English; now an accepted national standard. (Burridge and Mulder, 1999)
- **African American Vernacular English (AAVE)** (*ebonics*) A rule-governed, systematic variety with distinctive grammar (e.g. copula absence, habitual *be*). Frequently stigmatized despite high linguistic complexity and cultural prestige (music, media). (Rickford, 1999)
- **Appalachian / Southern US English** Often mischaracterized as “incorrect”; has unique grammatical systems (e.g. a-prefixing: *He’s a-running*, multiple modals *I shoulda coulda done it*). Example of **overt vs. covert prestige**. (Lippi-Green, 2012)
- **British regional dialects** (Scouse, Geordie, Glaswegian) Local prestige but low institutional prestige; hard for outsiders to understand.

Takeaway: The ideology that Inner Circle Englishes are uniform “standards” is false: *all Englishes exhibit prestige hierarchies.*

Linking Inner-Circle Variation to Asian Englishes

The same social processes shaping variation in Inner Circle Englishes also affect Asian Englishes.

- **Covert prestige:** Speakers may value a stigmatized variety as an identity marker. *Strine*, *AAVE*, *Singlish* all show strong in-group solidarity.
- **Standard language ideology** The belief that one form of English is inherently “better”. Used to delegitimize AAVE, regional UK dialects, and Asian Englishes (e.g. Indian English, HK English).
- **Error vs. innovation:** Just as AAVE grammatical rules were long misclassified as errors, many Asian English features start as “deviations” but become recognized innovations.
- **Ownership of English:** Debates around AAVE in schools parallel arguments about whether Indian English or Singlish should be taught, legitimized, or standardized.
- Understanding Inner-Circle diversity helps avoid seeing Asian varieties as special cases: *all Englishes are dialects*. (Milroy and Milroy, 1999)

Conclusion

- Asian Englishes showcase the dynamic evolution of the language.
- They are key to understanding the future of global English.
- How established they are depends on their size and prestige.

Activity: Innovation, Deviation, or Mistake?

Decide in pairs how to classify each sentence. For each one, ask:

- Is this an **innovation** (accepted in some community)?
- A **deviation** (different from a chosen standard)?
- Or a **mistake** (not accepted anywhere)?

- (1) *Can you prepone the meeting to tomorrow?*
- (2) *Yesterday I go market, very crowded, lah.*
- (3) *He is knowing the answer.*
- (4) *She is 22 years.*
- (5) *This food is damn shiok!*
- (6) *They knowed the answer.*
- (7) *I need to control my homework.*
- (8) *I beez in the trap.*

Whose norms are you using when you decide?

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